

**Democratic Decentralization and Empowerment of Women: (With
Special Reference to Oraon Tribes of Mandar Block Ranchi District)
A Sociological Analysis**



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Introduction

Empowerment, Democratic Decentralization, People's participation etc are some of the critical concepts in the contemporary discourse on development, particularly in the context of gender. Issue of women's subordination and their invisibility in public life especially in the decision-making bodies are very often considered as a major obstacle for development with social equality and justice to all. In India with the introduction of constitutional amendment, assured participation of women in panchayats and with various initiatives taken by the Government the quantum of representation and participation of women in local political bodies have gone up however how far this participation actually contributed to the empowerment of women in general and women of marginalised communities like SCs/STs in particular is still a concern for academics and policy makers. The proposed study titled "Democratic Decentralization and Empowerment of Women: (With special Reference to Oraon Tribes of Mandar Block Ranchi District) A Sociological Analysis" is mainly an attempt to understand the impact of democratic decentralisation and assured representation of women in local decision-making bodies vis a vis their empowerment and community development. The study is proposed to be conducted in a selected panchayat dominantly inhabited by the Oraon community in the Mander block of Ranchi district, Jharkhand.

India is the largest democracy in the world with a rich democratic heritage. The idea of local self-government and to an extent democratic decentralization has existed in Indian society for many centuries. The present form of democratic decentralization evolved after independence over a period through a series administrative reform. The three-tier system

of Panchayati Raj became a constitutional mandate after the 73rd constitutional amendment in 1992-93. However even after three decades of democratic decentralization and functioning of local self-government institutions, its impacts upon various communities, gender, caste, class, and regions in India is a debatable for researchers, academics, policy makers and others in general.

The main purpose of democracy is to ensure effective participation of people in the decision-making process and to ensure their welfare and the progress. After Independence, with adoption of Universal Adult Franchise which is a fundamental feature of Constitutional Democracy equal participation of all sections of society was expected in the decision-making process. However active participation of under privileged sections of society like scheduled castes, scheduled tribes, minorities and particularly of women has been an area of concern both in terms of quantum (number) and quality across democratic institutions and political parties/forums in India. The socio demographic analysis of the limited number of women who got elected at various levels of Indian political system at both legislative and party forums show visible discrimination towards the women from lower sections of society.

Democracy is not merely an administrative mechanism. It is a value, which encompass freedom, equality, and justice to everybody irrespective of caste, class and gender. In a country like India with its stupendous diversity and plurality, democracy can be successful only through the assured participation of the people from different sections of the society. The core idea of democracy is the belief that every person within the community is equally entitled to a life of dignity, self-respect, and wellbeing. People's participation is very much central to democracy, whether it be direct or indirect. Hence the question of empowerment is vitally connected to democratic polity.

Politics is not the only route to women's emancipation but indeed a significant one, which reflects the power relations existing in a society and manifests through decision making process. Hence it affects directly resource distribution, its utilization and wellbeing of any society. Direct participation of people makes a democracy successful. But mere participation, let say physical presence would not bring about desired changes and progress in a society. Participation with self-realization and awareness is much more important. That is, an empowered participation is required for a better democracy. Empowerment in its broader sense is about creating knowledge, capacity building, realization of rights and capacity to demand and protest. In a more specific sense, the reference is to the assured representation and participation to the deprived groups in day-to day governance. In such a democracy the government would be more responsive to the needs of the people, or it would be accessible to them. The more democracy comes closer to the people the more democratic it becomes. So, the issue of empowerment is germane to democracy.

Decentralization, people's participation, and empowerment are some of the new catchwords in the contemporary discourse on development, especially in the Third World countries. These are widely acknowledged as an instrument to achieve equality and social justice. While the latter goals have been widely endorsed for quite some time, but their realization remain largely unfulfilled. Therefore, the instrumentalities have been invoked in recent times. In India democratic decentralization became important after independence from the point of view of twin objects of democracy and development. The same is reflected in Indian constitution as well. Article 40 of Indian constitution directs the government of India to organize village panchayats and endow them with powers of self-government to cope with this problem. Appointment of Balwant Rai Mehta study team in 1957 to consider the institutional framework and suggest measures for mobilizing local resources was the first step taken in this direction. The Committee reported in 1958, that Community Development Programme launched in 1952 failed to get expected public co-

operation. As a solution, Panchayati Raj Institutions (PRIs) as an institutional form of democratic decentralization with three tiers-at District, Block, and Panchayat-- were suggested. In conformity to this many states enacted Panchayat Raj Acts. But a unified form of Panchayati Raj Institutions with statutory powers, first time in the history of India came into being with 73rd and 74th amendments of Indian constitution in 1992-93.

From the perspective of women's empowerment, 73rd and 74th Amendment Act of Indian constitution is quite radical of its kind. It ensures one-third reservation for women in all the three tiers of local bodies including the post of presidents. As a natural sequence of 73rd amendment, the number /physical participation of women across the state has gone up in local bodies and in public life in general, however the quality of participation like freedom in taking independent decisions, freedom to attend in meetings /active public life, participation in deliberations, financial responsibilities, ability to influence the fund allocations, utilization etc. have been still a matter of concern.

After introduction of 73rd & 74th constitutional amendments most of the states in India came up with their own version of Panchayati Raj Acts and conducted elections resulting large number of women getting elected to Panchayati Raj Institutions.

Jharkhand also passed its Act in 2001, however due to litigations and other reason the first elections to the newly formed PRIs in the state could be conducted in 2010. In 2010 election in all three levels of panchayats total 51,285 representatives were elected to the 53207 seats. A total of 29,415 women were got elected constituting 57.56% of the total seats. Total 2353 posts of Mukhiyas and 2435 seats in panchayat Samitis were held by Women. In 2015 elections too large number of women across the spectrum got elected. In 2015 out of total 64700 seats 34019, i.e., 52.18% were reserved for women, in which 11113 seats were reserved for women from ST community. A Total of 30757 women representatives and 2420 women chairpersons were got elected. In addition to reserved

seats few women got elected from general seats too taking women's representation even higher.

From above discussion it's clear that with the introduction of mandatory reservation of women in panchayats the number of women in Local Self Government Institutions has gone up considerably. With 50% reservation of seats to women in Jharkhand also large number of women were got elected to local government bodies. The provision of mandatory quorum of one third women in Gram Sabha also introduced in the state as a progressive and effective tool to ensure participation of women grassroot democracy. Although statutory provisions ensured the quantum of participation of women the actual quality of women's participation and how far it helped in empowering women is an area of concern, needs to be studied in detail. This study will try to analyze the reservation of women in Local Self Government Institutions from the perspective of quality of participation and its impact on women's empowerment, actual role of tribal women in decision making process, role of information technology in promoting women's participation, the impact of democratic decentralization and the improved participation in the day today life of women and in empowering them as equal partners in resource allocation/control as well as in development.

State of the Art (Literature Review)

The concept of decentralization, participation, and empowerment are widely discussed in various literatures by various social scientists as a tool to achieve equality and social justice. These concepts are not mutually exclusive, but vitally interlinked. There is no universally accepted definition of the concept of decentralization. The liberal interventionists consider decentralization as an effective means to make governments more effective in development and administration. In this view administrative decentralization is much more important than democratic decentralization or political decentralization. It is

more about organization of government to increase efficiency and reduce delays. Here the role of people is very limited and confined to political participation in terms of voting. According to liberal interventionists such a governmental organization will promote the process of local resource mobilization, democracy and better co-ordination and integration of developmental activities. For liberal interventionists decentralization is more technical, a policy matter and constitutional. They believe that effective decentralization will promote economic growth, hence, more welfare and development, which in-turn will reduce inequalities. For them people's participation is a strategy for quick and successful implementation of development programmes. Citizens are beneficiaries rather than planners or managers. For them popular empowerment is desirable but not a major concern.

The radical populist view is primarily concerned with political decentralization, more precisely democratic decentralization. This approach to development is 'bottom to top'. For them the central concern is mass empowerment. 'People first' is their slogan. According to this perspective development is not merely economic growth, but growth with equity. Hence, decentralization is considered as "democratic redistribution of political power to the grassroots". For radical populists' decentralization is not simply a means but also a goal. It ensures mass mobilization for democratization at the grassroots through various strategies of political empowerment of the weak.

Despite these two differing streams of thought what we have seen in general in different places where decentralization is being introduced, is a mixture of ideas drawn arbitrarily from these two schools of thought. In India democratic decentralization and local government institutions are not new ideas, we had the Gandhian notion of 'Gramswaraj' during the freedom struggle itself. The same got reflected in our constitution also. That is in the popular consciousness decentralization is a public policy of the central government aiming to speed up development by meeting local needs more quickly through politically

empowered local governments. It makes administration efficient, accountable, responsive and brings government closer to the people. It improves the link between demand and meeting of people's need and facilitates better mobilization of local resources.

Most of the literature on decentralization and Local Self Government Institutions (LSGIS) are primarily based on the liberal normative assumptions. Based on that there are three types of decentralization. These are delegation, de-concentration, and devolution. According to United Nation's Development Programme's (UNDP) report on Human Development 1993, decentralization means passing down of limited administrative discretions to local offices of central government ministries. Delegation involves passing down of some authority and decision-making powers to local offices. But central government retains its right to change the decisions taken by local governments and can even take away their powers at any time. Devolution, the strongest among these, means granting decision-making powers to local authorities and allowing them to take full responsibility without referring to central government. This includes financial powers as well as the authority to design and execute local development projects and programmes.

Our understanding of decentralization does not totally conform to any of these models and yet not totally different from them. The democratic decentralization that we are talking about is a process initiated in India immediately after independence and legalized through the 73rd amendment of Indian Constitution in 1993. It is a form of devolution coupled with democracy. Decentralization may not be necessarily democratic. The prefix democratic not only gives a special meaning to it but also distinguishes it from other forms of decentralization, bringing the element of empowerment to it. So democratic decentralization is an extension of the democratic principles of people's right to manage their own affairs in a local area without any undue interference from regional or national authorities. It makes democracy meaningful by ensuring people's participation in the day-

to-day governance. Democratic decentralization thus establishes grassroot democracy. That is "democratic decentralization" is a political ideal and local self-government is its institutional form. It is democratic in the sense; power is decentralized from a democratic source as well as power is devolved to a democratically organized body.

There is nothing new in saying that people's participation is inherent to democratic decentralization. It is not simply a desirable pre-requisite for democracy, but also a necessary condition. According to J.S. Mill, "The only government which can fully satisfy all the exigencies of the social state is one in which the whole people participate". The more people participate the more democracy becomes meaningful; and it comes closer to the people. People's participation gives legitimacy to the system. Participation is the essence of liberty and freedom. It is not a simple question of presence, but an opportunity, by which people can control, influence, and share the policies and resources of the country. The question of popular participation is not only significant for a successful democracy. According to liberal interventionist school of thought, the term participation means collaboration of people of all strata in planning and execution of development activities on the local levels. It is viewed as a strategy for rapid implementation of development projects. Universal franchise is enough for them to claim political participation. They see participation as an inclusion of human resources or as an input to development projects. For radical populist school, participation is a process whereby poor people seek to have some influence and gain access to the resources, which would help them to sustain and improve their living standards. They focus on power relation and argue that genuine participation involves structural changes and empowerment. It strives to enable the poor people to decide upon and to take the actions which they believe as essential to their development. People's participation is, therefore, a major movement for political empowerment of the poor and other underprivileged sections of the grassroots. It enables them to function influentially in the process of local level planning and execution. Hence, the political participation is

viewed as a process whereby poor people gain access to local resources, improve their standard of living, and exert political power through local governance so for national development.

The word empowerment got much currency in the recent developmental debate. It is because feminists, human right champions and other social activists have been invoking this idea in their pursuit of freedom and justice. It is not only because of its strong appeal for change, but also because of its capacity to challenge the existing socio- political, economic, and cultural subordinations of weaker sections in a society. These subordinations are often rooted in the prevailing social and power structure, gender relations, culture, and ideology. Now the old formulation of growth with social justice has been reformulated as development with empowerment. Empowerment to put it simply implies giving power to a certain underprivileged section of the society. This view of empowerment is very much consistent with the dictionary meaning of the term, that is, to give someone the official or legal authority or the freedom to do something.

Etymologically the word empowerment is rooted in the concept of power. Power is central to any understanding of empowerment. That is, any notion of empowerment cannot be separated from the idea of power. As Beteille observes, although the concept of power in it (empowerment) is generally left unspecified, ultimately it is all about power. Power is a universal phenomenon in human societies; it is inherent in all kinds of social relations. That is power is not simply political, it is very much social also. Broadly referred, political power--legal, administrative, military, economic--is only one of several and various kind of powers.

Power in sociology is not a consensually defined concept. It has diverse meanings and connotations. As pointed out by R. Bierstedt: "In the entire lexicon of sociological concept, none is more troublesome than the concept of power". According to Lewis Coser, there are

two major traditions in the conceptualization of power. First, "power may be seen as the imposition of the will of actor A (who may be either an individual or a collectivity) upon actor B, even against B's resistance: so that B is dominated by A". Secondly, "power may be conceptualized as a resource at the disposal of collectivities and used for their benefits, allowing them to attain their objectivities". First explanation is basically that of Weber's who defined power as follows: "in general, we understand by power, the chance of a man or a number of men to realize their own will in a social action even against the resistance of others, who are participating in the action." Here power is based on the notion of domination and subordination or action and resistance. In its very nature power is asymmetrical and represent the 'power over' view of power. According to this understanding of power, one party can enhance its power only by reducing the power of others. So, empowerment of some sections of society must be accompanied by disempowerment of the other.

In India there are many studies available on various aspects of democratic decentralisation, political participation and empowerment of women with special focus on different states on quantum of participation of women in general but very few or negligible on Jharkhand, its women and Oraon a prominent tribal group in the state. Some of the important studies are reviewed and summarised below.

Review of the Existing Literature

Tyagi Amarendra (2002) "Dalit and Tribal Leadership in Panchayats" analyses Dalit and tribal leadership in Local Self Government Institutions after the implementation of 73rd constitutional amendment. Socio economic profile of Dalit leaders in panchayat, their participation, obstacles, provisions of Panchayats (Extension to the scheduled Areas) Act 1996, Implication of Panchayat Laws in scheduled Areas of Jharkhand, Tribal Women in local governance with special reference to Andhra Pradesh etc. In the Jharkhand study an attempt has been made to evaluate Jharkhand PESA 1996, about the empowerment of the

Gram Sabha and how it's being helpful for their socio-political upliftment, implication of traditional governance system etc.

Baviskar BS & Mathew George ed. (2009) "Inclusion and Exclusion in Local Governance, Field Studies from Rural India" is a compilation experiences across different states. It reveals the nature of working of democratic decentralization in Indian villages of 12 major states. Issues regarding empowerment, discrimination against women, scheduled castes and scheduled tribes also have been dealt with. Experiences varies across the states, caste, gender, and communities. It also depends on the socio-economic factors, state policies etc. Various articles also studied power dynamics, issues of empowerment, changing power relations with special reference to women and other marginalized sections of society. Though the book studied 12 major states no reference to Bihar and Jharkhand in specific.

Meenakshi J (2012) "Women and Panchayati Raj" presents a pan India view on women in panchayat raj system. The book is a compilation of outcome and discussion of a participatory appraisal. Authors argues that the constitutional amendment providing one third representation to women in elected bodies as well as reserving one third of the offices of chairpersons for them will have far reaching consequences in Indian political and social life. In a traditional society of our democracy can't be meaningful without full involvement of women.

Hasan Zoya & Menon Ritu ed. (2005) "In a Minority, Essays on Muslim Women in India", this edited work based on empirical studies presents the diversity of Muslim women's lives in all its complexity. Various chapters discussing the material and social circumstances in shaping the lives of Muslim women. Among other socio economic and cultural issues there are chapters on participation of Muslim women in electoral politics, panchayat raj and leadership as well. The chapter on Panchayati Raj and women in Kerala also discusses theoretical aspects of decentralization, devolution, and empowerment.

Kathyayan Rashmi (2013) “Jharkhand Panchayati Raj Handbook”. The book is a collection of different Acts and rules pertaining to panchayat with special focus to state Acts, rules. It also has information on supreme court judgement on PESA, constitutional provisions on scheduled areas, traditional system of governance, power, functions, and responsibilities various institutions including Gram Sabha.

Palanithurai G ed. (2004) “Dynamics of Panchayati Raj System in India”, the multi volume work examines the various aspect of political decentralization in India. Volume IV specifically deals with the question of empowerment. Experiences from different states like Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nādu etc. have been compiled and analysed. The volume addresses wide range of issues concerning women empowerment in planning, finance, people’s participation, resource management, capacity building, leadership, and challenges etc. The article on ‘Role of women in Decentralization’ argues that women’s experience of local government cannot be used merely in a limited gender focused manner to enhance the participation of women and to improve women’s contribution to the panchayat’s achievement. The Volume also carries article on experiences from Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala with special focus on decentralization and empowerment. It also examines the role of grass root institutions in addressing various issues related to women.

Singh MK (2014) “Panchayati Raj System in India, Issues and Challenges” Panchayati raj institutions are considered as the vehicle of socio-economic transformation of rural India. The sizable presence of women and other underprivileged sections of rural populace in the local self-government institutions is a landmark development in the political history of the country. The 73rd constitutional amendment and the subsequent elections in different states geared this change, though the quality of participation is debatable. The book examines the various aspects like women’s awareness on Panchayati Raj Institutions, historical

evolution, development and management of Panchayati Raj Institutions, role of women in local governance vis-vis rural development.

Mathew Abraham (2005) “Role of Panchayats in Welfare Administration” apart from the theoretical discussion on welfare administration the study examines the role of local self-government institution in ensuring public welfare at the grass roots. The study also highlights the importance of 73rd constitutional amendment in ensuring democratic decentralization and participation of women and other marginalized sections of society.

Mathew George ed for ISS (2013), examines the status of Panchayati raj institutions across the states in the country. This report compiled for institute of social science New Delhi has an in-depth analysis of the working of Panchayati Raj Institutions in the country. The chapter on Jharkhand gives a clear view on system of local governance starting from traditional self-governance system to modern Panchayati Raj Institutions. The chapter not only analyses the historical evolution of panchayats in the state but also attempted to contextualize the same in the contexts of traditional tribal village administrative system and tenancy laws. The article also discusses the administrative structure of 3 tier panchayats, elections, devolution of power, training and capacity building etc.

Seth Sachi (2016) “PRI Elections in Jharkhand: Making Women Count” analyses the post-election scenario in Jharkhand with supporting stories/experiences from elected women representatives. Though the Panchayati Raj Institutions and election under the new act is relatively new in Jharkhand there was a surge in political participation of women and 56% seats were won by women. Despite many success stories the author argues that though the representation of women gone up beyond reservation when it comes to decision making often decisions are taken behest male politician or husbands. The paper concludes with an observation that Panchayati Raj elections are a step towards better engagement with the state so that the rural people can fight for their right sand take their problems to the state

through their representatives. What is necessary to make this process successful in its objective of strengthening rural populations is the involvement of all communities and strata of society.

Vidyarthi LP & Rai Ninay Kumar (1976) “The Tribal culture Of India” is a detailed anthropological study of tribal society-social organization, political, religious, and cultural life. For understanding political participation of tribal community, it is very important to understand the traditional social organization and political life of tribals. The book argues that the political life of the tribals of India reflects a paradoxical situation in which democracy and monarchy coexists. Clan, hereditary, lineage etc. has important role in community leadership. The tribal leader governs the community only because he is backed by the majority or the whole of the group. The Munda’s of Chota Nagpur elect their head. The political characteristic of tribals broadly be looked through their social organization. They are based on clan lineage, a unit village, and a group of villages within a territory. Different tribal groups have different traditions, nature, customs which governs the political life. Among the Mundas, Oraons, Hos and Kharias the panchayath consists of the influential and elderly persons of the village including non-tribal members living in the area. With the advent of statutory village panchayats sponsored by government in many areas both statutory panchayats and traditional panchayats started working in parallel.

Oraon Prakash Chandra (2003) “Land and people of Jharkhand” is a comprehensive account of Jharkhand the newly born state its land people. The book has an exhaustive collection of socio-political life various tribal communities living in Jharkhand. The chapter on Oraons analyses the culture, social structure and institutions like family, religion, marriage, kinship, economy, political organizations etc. The Oraons have traditional political organization like village panchayat and inter village panchayat called

Parha Panchayat. It also discusses the roles and responsibilities panchayat, dispute redressal mechanism etc.

Singh Sunil Kumar (2012) “Inside Jharkhand” is a comprehensive depiction of Jharkhand, its history, geography, minerals, industry, development, administrative structure etc. The book provides detailed information and data on various aspects including socio-demographic profile of each district. It also provides basic information about the family and social organization of different tribal communities. The chapter on administrative system of Jharkhand also discusses the evolution of Panchayati raj institutions in the state.

EPW Engage (2019) “Where are the women in Indian Politics” analyses the agency of women in bringing changes in the political space of India. Though the voting turnout of women has gone up considerably over the years the article poses the larger question that an increase in number necessarily indicate more meaningful political participation? The article argues that “To understand that women, as a category, cannot be treated as uniform—especially as a political category. Caste, class, and demographic differences need to be accounted for if we wish to understand the nuances of how and why women vote because these intersections are instrumental in defining the political aspirations that these women may have. Socio-economic differences are also crucial when we try to understand how much space a woman can carve for herself in the political sphere”. The article examines 4 major questions in details that are is voting participation affects female empowerment, making political decisions-whom to vote, how active the elected women in democratic process and how much they can influence in decision making.

Rajunayak Vislavath & Sunitha Bhukya (2021) “Limits of the Modern Political System: The case of an Erukula Woman Sarpanch in Telangana” explain how the social status of an elected woman from a tribal community did not change and questions of limitations of modern state power in the form of democratic decentralisation through Panchayati raj act.

The paper is ethnographic report on the story of an elected sarpanch from the nomadic tribal community called Erukula in Telangana. It analyses the layers of social oppression and the political structure and its inbuilt limitations that affects the working of women in panchayats and the resultant empowerment. The author argues that for many, Panchayati raj institutions held out the promise of genuine democracy and decentralisation. However, over the last few decades, the state's constant attempts to minimise the role of these institutions in democratic participation and administrative decision-making has made it difficult to hold on to such optimism.

Srivatsa P (2016) "Political empowerment of women and Panchayati Raj" argues that the adoption of the 73rd amendment had a great revolutionary potential to create genuine democracy at the grassroots level, a historic opportunity to change the face of rural India. The amendment mandates that resources, responsibility and decision-making power be devolved from central government to Panchayati Raj Institutions. The author argues that empowerment of women in all spheres particularly in political sphere is very crucial for their advancement and for foundation gender equal society. Political empowerment of women starts with the active participation of women in political institutions.

Jephy Medonna (2022) "Women Empowerment through Panchayati Raj system" argues that though at present women enjoy equal status with men as per the constitution and legal provisions but still, they have a long way to go. It is true and proved that "a country prospers if its women prosper". So, women's empowerment is vital towards the development of the society. 'Empowerment' means 'to authorize'. In the context of the people, they must be authorized to have control over their own lives. Empowerment is an only effective answer to oppression, exploitation, injustice, and other melodies of society. In short, Women empowerment means to give women the opportunity to fulfil their

creative capabilities and desires and take decisions independently. It has social, political, economic, cultural dimensions.

Sinha Shrishti (2021) “Political empowerment of women through restructured Panchayati Raj institutions” is an in-depth analysis on evolution and functioning of Panchayati Raj Institutions in India. It concludes that the women’s political empowerment can begin with Panchayati Raj Institutions since their confidence and grasp of the polity will enable them to vote in elections to state legislatures and parliament, opening the route from “Panchayat to Parliament”. They can even get the confidence to take a stand for themselves, but it is only the start of a journey toward empowerment. Women’s empowerment requires more than local reservations and women’s involvement in Panchayati Raj institutions because the mindset that women are meant for households has still not changed, women are still not educated. Still, women are oppressed and are denied their rights and they face many more hurdles. But the Panchayati Raj Institutions are great initiatives to make women strong either politically, economically, or socially

Raghunandan T R (2012) “Decentralisation and Local Governments The Indian experience” is a compilation of essays published in EPW over different period of time. The edited volume contains 25 essays discussing various facets of local self-government institutions in India, its evolution, its functioning, its impact , experiences from different states including women’s role in local governance and decision making . Few essays are focused on gender perspective and women’s participation in PRIs. The essay titled “Women in Panchyati Raj” by Vyasulu and Vyasulu analyses the experience of women from Malgudi in Karnataka. The essay analysing various factors like gender, caste, class and religious identities and women’s participation concludes with caution that “PRIs as grass roots democratic governance institutions are a necessity but not sufficient condition in the transformation to a better social order”. There is also a chapter on “Networks of Panchayat Women” by Behar and Aiyer on interface of Civil Society Organisation and women in PRIs

and its contribution in capacity building, mobility and empowerment. Another essay by M E Jhon titled “Women in Power” discusses various aspects covering gender, caste and politics in local governance. The collected works also having various chapters on impact of reservation, fiscal decentralisation, women leaders in urban local bodies in Kerala etc among others.

Relevance of the present-day problem and needs of society

The issue of women empowerment is many folded-economic, social, and political. In a democracy effective participation of each person is very crucial in terms of health of nation as well as welfare of its citizens. Women constitute 50% of the human resources the of nation. However, the participation women in various domains of public life like social, economic, and political spheres are still not encouraging. The invisibility of women in public life in general and in politics always been an area of concern for all. All over the country women’s participation in Panchayati Raj Institutions have gone up. However elected women as an agency of social change, how much they can take up the issues pertaining to women- gender discrimination, violence, development deficit, role in decision making, invisibility of women in public life etc. is need thorough analysis across the communities. The present study is attempted to understand the impact of democratic decentralization upon women empowerment with special focus to Oraon women. The outcome of this study certainly will help policy makers, planners, social activists, and researchers to understand the real issues and challenges of tribal women’s participation and find out the solutions for the same. Further the positive outcomes may be replicated if needed to address the issues of women’s invisibility and subordination.

Problem to be investigated

As it is evident from above discussion hardly any study available on impact of democratic decentralisation and empowerment of women specific to Oraon communities of

Jharkhand. Hence this study intent to take up the case of women belonging to Oraon, one of the major tribal communities in Jharkhand. How far the increased representation of women actually contributing to their empowerment and the development. It also will examine the role of various government initiatives and the role information technology in transforming the women's leadership and the quality of their participation in the decision-making process, setting agendas and in policy decisions concerning their life. The study will certain help not only to bridge the existing gap in knowledge but also will contribute immensely to understand the issues of tribal women in local governing system and ways to improve the quality of their participation in the decision-making process. It also will assist the policy makers in modifying if necessary or intervene further depending upon the findings of the study.

Objective of the Investigation

Undoubtedly the representation of women and political participation of women in general has gone up considerably after the 73rd constitutional amendment mandating reservation of 50% seats for women in local government institutions. It ensured the number however its impact in terms of empowerment, at the qualitative level is still a major concern. Further the benefits of reservation leading to empowerment varies among different communities, gender, and class. It also is a function of many other socio-cultural and political factors. Major objectives of the present study are:

1. To examine the impact of the 73rd constitutional Amendment on women's representation and participation in PRIs in India and its contribution to their empowerment
2. To Evaluate effectiveness of the capacity building initiatives for women's leadership and participation in decentralized government structures in India

3. To assess the role of information and communication technology in promoting women's participation in empowerment in decentralized governance structures in India
4. To explore the extent to which women's participation in village level decision making bodies have contributed to the empowerment and development of their communities

Hypothesis

Mentioned below are the hypotheses proposed to be tested in the proposed study of democratic decentralization and the empowerment of women.

1. The 73rd constitutional amendment lead to increase in women's representation and participation in PRIs , which has contributed to their empowerment
2. Capacity building initiatives for women's leadership and participation in decentralized government structures have been effective in enhancing their participation and promoting their empowerment
3. Information and communication technology have played a crucial role in promoting women's participation in decentralized government structures in India
4. Women's participation in village level decision making bodies have contributed significantly to their empowerment and the development of their communities.

Research Design and Methodology

Conducting research on democratic decentralization in tribal women requires a culturally sensitive and gender-responsive research methodology that considers the complexities of power dynamics and community context. The study would therefore be carried out using a specific research methodology that will consider the cultural context, gender dynamics, and power structures at play. Here is a general outline of a potential research methodology which will be used:

Research Design: The first step is to determine the research design that will best suit the research question. A descriptive research design with a mix of qualitative and quantitative research tools such as nonparticipant observation, structured questionnaire, interview with elected representative etc. may be used in collection of data for this study as it allows for an in-depth understanding of the experiences, perspectives, and practices of tribal women in democratic decentralization.

Sampling: Next will be the need to identify the population of tribal women who participate in democratic decentralization. A purposive sampling method may be used to select women who are actively engaged in the democratic process as this would ensure that the sample is representative of the population being studied, rather than relying on random sampling, which may not necessarily reflect the diversity of experiences among tribal women. The study is proposed to be carried out in Brambey gram panchayat of Mandar block. The panchayat has total 15 wards in which 13 of them are occupied by women elected representatives. The panchayat head and both members of panchayat Samiti is also women. As far as possible experiences of all these women elected representatives would be taken. There are 1341 households covering 4712 voters and more than 50% are women in the panchayat. Hence 80-100 women voters will be randomly selected as sample to understand the general perspective of women on their participation in local politics and empowerment.

Data Collection: A combination of primary and secondary data would be collected and analysed to provide an objective and verifiable evidence to support the hypothesis. Primary data collection methods would include collection of data through questionnaire, semi-structured and structured interviews, non-participant observation, and document analysis. The use of non-participatory methods such as focus group discussions may be particularly useful to encourage open and honest dialogue. Sources of secondary data

would include relevant literature, reports, research papers, online materials pertaining to the topic of study.

Analysis: Analysis of the obtained data would be conducted using appropriate software or through manual coding of the data. Thematic analysis might be used for identifying patterns and themes in the data.

Ethics: Ethical considerations are essential when conducting research with vulnerable populations such as tribal women. Informed consent would be obtained, and confidentiality and anonymity will be maintained throughout the research process.

Area of Study

The study would be focusing the impact of functioning Panchayati Raj Institutions among Oraon community of Jharkhand. Oraon is an important rather dominant tribal group in Jharkhand. They live mainly in Chotanagpur region of Jharkhand. Ranchi is one of the scheduled districts falling in the region. The present study would be concentrating on Mandar block which has large concentration tribal communities i.e., 60% of its population. Among tribal population Oraon constitute 80 %. Hence Mander is a natural choice for study of political participation of women among Oraon in Jharkhand. In Mandar block Brambey panchayat is proposed for detailed study and sampling. Brambey panchayat is dominated by Tribal communities with 74 % of tribal population mainly of Oraons.

Significance of the Study

The democratic decentralization and the introduction modern Panchayati Raj Institutions helped in assuring the participation of women in public life. However, the situation is not uniform across the communities and the region. Though there is a quantum jump in

numbers there are many qualitative issues and challenges that women are facing. In Jharkhand Panchayat elections are held after much delay in 2010. The PRI in the modern form is relatively new in Jharkhand. However, data from past two elections shows that there is a considerable surge in numbers in terms of women elected representatives. However how much this participation is working as a tool for empowerment and social change is needs to be studied. There are not many studies on participation of tribal women in panchayats so far with focus on Jharkhand. Oraon are one of the dominant tribal communities in Jharkhand has been playing a significant role in the public life of Jharkhand. However, the role of Panchayati Raj Institutions in addressing the larger questions of rural development, bridging gender gap, addressing the issues of women empowerment etc. are yet to known. This study intent analyses the role of decentralization and its impact on women in terms improving their social status and empowerment.

Contribution of the existing knowledge

Political empowerment of women is very much critical for the national development and to ensure gender equity. Power structure in society is mainly male oriented and women are often considered the victims. Though the constitutional amendment and statutory reservation of women in Local Self Government Institutions certainly helped in improving participation of women in local governance and politics. However qualitative participation of elected women in the real decision-making process is still a matter of concern. Women in panchayats are often controlled by the patriarchal power structure both at social and family level. Voices of elected women members are often ignored or neglected. Whether elected women or the improved participation of women translated to empowerment or are they able to take up gender agenda forward in these local bodies etc. need detailed analysis. The present study will try to answer this question and will analyses

various factors that affecting the participation of women in politics/ Local Self Government Institutions.

Future work

The outcome of the study will be useful to policy makers, social scientists, social activists, administrators etc. to design and make necessary changes in the policy making and address the development deficit because of meagre or ineffective participation. This also will help to address the question of empowerment from the perspective of socially deprived tribal women. It also will bring out role of information technology, awareness generation etc in enhancing women's participation, the importance of financial devolution, enabling legal frame works and institutional structures, capacity building etc. which are important to promote women's participation and empowerment.

Tentative Chapters

The proposed frame of chapters is:

1. Introduction
2. Review of the present literature
3. Research Area and research methodology
4. Socio Economic profile of the respondents
5. Interpretation and Data Analysis
6. Democratic decentralization, political participation, and Empowerment of Women.
7. Conclusion and Suggestion
8. Bibliography- Appendix.
9. Interview Schedule.
10. Map.
11. Photographs

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